which were well peopled, whereas the old city of Pataliputra was a somewhat unimpressive and decaying settlement, one that he characterized as ‘having long been a wilderness’ whose ‘foundation walls had survived’.[3] By this Xuanzang probably meant that the ruins of earlier buildings were still visible within the city. He had encountered such ruins in many places across India before, but, exceptionally in the case of Pataliputra, the visible traces of stupas, pillars, old towers, and strange stones seemed to him to be closely associated with Ashoka.

The associations appear to match many of the legends that by then surrounded Ashoka, and Xuanzang is likely to have been familiar with their Chinese versions.[4] So, for instance, the early part of Ashoka’s reign was recounted in them as being marked by much violence, since the emperor was known to have been a notoriously cruel tyrant at that point in his reign. Proof of his tyranny was an earth-prison or ‘hell’ which he had built, a place where all who entered ‘were killed without any chance of self defence’. After his conversion to Buddhism, the 84,000 stupas that Ashoka is supposed to have raised throughout his empire over the relics of the Buddha are specially mentioned, the first of these being recorded as created just south of the prison in Pataliputra. By the time of Xuanzang, this stupa was in ‘a leaning, ruinous condition’, though its crowning segment of carved stone, with a balustrade around it, had survived.

Then there was a stone on which the Buddha had apparently walked, marked by the impression of both his feet, a sacred feature which the king had surrounded within an enclosure. Modern archaeologists read the Chinese traveller’s description of these details with approval, Xuanzang having shown the sorts of precise measuring skills that are the staple of the discipline of archaeology: he mentions the dimensions of the sacred footprints (18 inches long and 6 inches broad), the circle signs embossed on them, and the manner in which fish and flowers fringed all ten toes. Not far from this stone, he noted a massive stone pillar with a mutilated inscription